Link to online syllabus: https://bit.ly/601-fall26 | Link to class notes: https://bit.ly/601-fall26-notes

Pratt
School of Information
144 West 14th Street, 6th floor
New York, NY 10011–7301

INFO-601 Foundations of Information

Course Information

Section: 03
Semester: Fall 2026
Meeting Dates & Times: Mondays, 6:30-9:20 pm
Location: Pratt Manhattan, room 214
Credits: 3
Prerequisites or other restrictions: None

Instructor Contact Information

Filipa Calado, PhD (she)
Office Location: Pratt Manhattan, room 602
Office Hours: Mondays 5:00pm - 6:00pm, Wednesdays 1:30pm-2:30pm, and by appointment
Phone: 718-687-5194
Email: fcalado@pratt.edu
Zoom: https://pratt.zoom.us/my/fcalado
Website: https://filipacalado.com

Course Description

This foundational course focuses on the intersection of people, information, and technology and the theoretical and conceptual foundations of the information field. Students will be introduced to ideas and concepts that will inform future specializations in their course of study and provide them with concrete strategies for ongoing professional growth and development in their area of interest.

Detailed Description

This section is taught from a critical perspective, which attends to structures of power in our concepts, actions, and social systems. Each week, we'll consider topics in the broad field of information organized around keywords like Cyborgs, “Artificial Intelligence,” Libraries and Archives, among others.

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Course Goals & Learning Outcomes

The goals of this course are to:

- introduce students to the major frameworks of the information field
- broaden students' understanding of information professions and careers in the information field
- help students to develop critical thinking, communication, research, management, presentation, and other skills required for successful completion of their programs and their professional growth

By the end of this course, students will be able to:

- describe and critique historical, political, economic, social, and ethical aspects of information environments, including:
    - various manifestations of information and internal and external factors affecting its production, distribution, and consumption
    - diversity of needs and characteristics of people, both individuals and communities, involved in information creation, management, and use
    - foundational methods for assessing information environments and actors' needs
    - basic elements of project and institutional management
- express professional voices for analyzing and evaluating information, contextualizing their views, and communicating them effectively
- identify and value opportunities for continuing professional development

Course Requirements

Sources and Materials

All readings are linked via this syllabus.

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Course Format

This is a seminar course, where each class is devoted to discussion of the required materials for that week, as well as current events and student work pertaining to those readings. You are required to review the assigned materials in advance of each session and prepare to discuss them in class.

Grading and Assignments

All assignments are due on the date indicated, and late work may receive reduced credit. Final grades will be awarded as follows:

Grade Evaluation	Quality	Points per Credit

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A	Excellent	4.0
A-	Excellent	3.7
B+	Very Good	3.3
B	Good	3.0
B-	Good	2.7
C+	Above Average	2.3
C	Average	2.0
F	Failure	0.0
WF	Lack of Attendance	0.0

Note: C is the lowest passing grade for graduate students.

Your grade in the course will be based on the following assignments:

Research paper (final project) 40%
Provocation posts 30%
Fieldwork 20%
Participation 10%

Provocation posts (30%)
For the first half of the semester, you will be expected to post a "provocation" based on one or more of the readings for that week. You are required to make at least one post per week, between 150 - 300 words (a mid- to large-size paragraph). You may post as a stand-alone or in response to a classmate's post.

Your provocation must be *provocative* in some way — it should state a novel insight or pose a question in a way that invites further discussion and perspectives. We will review strategies for writing a good provocation in class.

Fieldwork (2 activities, 10% each)
Throughout the semester, you should participate in at least two professional development opportunities and report back to the class through an informal discussion of 3-5 minutes, which may include questions from others. A writeup of your report should be submitted on Canvas. Examples of relevant activities include:

- attending professional events
- attending a live webinar (maximum 1 webinar)
- other ideas, which you should feel free to discuss with me at any time

Your written report can be written in an informal style, and should be about 200-300 words (⅔ page or 1 full page, double spaced, 12 point Times New Roman or Linux Libertine font).

All fieldwork must be completed and submitted before class on November 23.

Research Paper (40%)

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In this assignment, you will explore a research question based on a contemporary issue or discourse that is related to our class discussions or on information studies more broadly.

Requirements:

- A thesis statement which states an area of inquiry broadly related to our class readings and/or discussions.
- 5 sources minimum, with at least 2 being academic/peer-reviewed sources. Evidence incorporated into argument in an active and thoughtful way.
- 10-12 pages in length (double-spaced, 12 pt. Times New Roman or Linux Libertine font).
- Clear writing style.
- Proper and consistent MLA (or style of your choice) citation for all sources referenced.

Important dates

- Oct 26 - Research question due
- Nov 2 - 1 scholarly source due
- Nov 9 - Outline due
- Nov 16 - First half of draft (at least 5 pages) due
- Dec 7 - Full draft (10 pages) due
- Dec 8, 11:59pm - Final paper due

Course Calendar/Schedule

This is a tentative outline of topics, readings, and assignments. Please try not to read more than one week ahead, as I may add, delete, or substitute readings.

Week 1 (Aug 24) - Intro

Introduction to the course and discussion on reading for graduate school.

Readings (in class):

- Debbie Millman. "Opinion: If You're Over 40, You're Ready to Use A.I." *The New York Times*, 27 July 2026.

Week 2 (Aug 31) - "Artificial Intelligence," part I

Discussion post due

Readings:

- Emily Bender, Timnit Gebru, A. McMillan-Major , & Shmargret Shmitchell. "On the Dangers of Stochastic Parrots: Can Language Models Be Too Big?" In *Proceedings of the 2021 FAccT Conference* (pp. 610-623). 2021.
- OpenAI, "OpenAI's proposals for the U.S. AI Action Plan," March 13, 2025.
- Ted Chiang, short story, "Understand," from *Stories of Your Life and Others*, 2002.

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Week 3 (Sept 7) - Labor Day, no class

Week 4 (Sept 14) - Cyborgs

Discussion post due

Readings:

- Donna Haraway, "A Cyborg Manifesto: Science, Technology, and Socialist-Feminism in the Late Twentieth Century," from *Simians, Cyborgs, and Women: The Reinvention of Nature*. 1989. pp. 149-181.
- Wendy Hui Kyong Chun, "Introduction," from Discriminating Data: Correlation, Neighborhoods, and the New Politics of Recognition, 2021.
- Have a conversation with Eliza (and try to guess how it works): https://www.masswerk.at/elizabot/

Week 5 (Sept 21) - Data

Discussion post due

Readings:

- Shoshana Zuboff, "Big Other: Surveillance Capitalism and the Prospects of an Information Civilization" *Journal of Information Technology* (30): 75–89, 2015.
- Ulises A. Mejias and Nick Couldry, "Chapter One" from *Data Grab: The New Colonialism of Big Tech and How to Fight Back*, 2024.
- J. Adema and S.A Moore, "Scaling Small; Or How to Envision New Relationalities for Knowledge Production", Westminster Papers in Communication and Culture 16(1), 27-45. 2021.

Potential fieldwork event: September 23, 1pm, online: Protecting Democracy's Data

Week 6 (Sept 28) - Code

Discussion post due

Readings:

- Lawrence Lessig, "Open code and open societies: values of internet governance," *Chicago-Kent Law Review* 74, 101–116, 1999.
- Ruha Benjamin, "Introduction" from *Race After Technology: Abolitionist Tools For The New Jim Code*. John Wiley & Sons, 2019.
- Tara McPherson, "US Operating Systems at Midcentury" from *Race After the Internet*, eds. Nakamura and Chow-White, 2012

Week 7 (Oct 5) - "Artificial Intelligence" part II

Discussion post due

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Readings:

- Caroline de Cock, *AI Tools, Not Gods* (2025), Part I & Part II, pages 1 - 145.

Week 8 (Oct 12) - Libraries and Archives

Discussion post due

Readings:

- Cait McKinney, Body, Sex, Interface: Reckoning with Images at the Lesbian Herstory Archives. *Radical History Review* 122: 115–28. 2015.
- Emily Drabinski, "Queering the Catalog: Queer Theory and the Politics of Correction." *The Library Quarterly: Information, Community, Policy*, vol. 83, no. 2, pp. 94–111. 2013.
- Saidiya Hartman, "Venus in Two Acts." *Small Axe*, vol. 12 no. 2, p. 1-14. *Project MUSE*, 2008.
- Elizaveta Kozina and Toson, Christian, "Anna, the Universal Library". *La Rivista di Engramma* (222): 243–259. 2025.

Week 9 (Oct 19) - Field work event

Week 10 (Oct 26) - Design

Discussion post due

Readings:

- Sasha Costanza-Chock, "Introduction" in *Design Justice: Community-Led Practices to Build the Worlds We Need*, 2020.
- Casey Fiesler, et al., "An Archive of Their Own: A Case Study of Feminist HCI and Values in Design." *Proceedings of the 2016 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems*, Association for Computing Machinery, pp. 2574–85. *ACM Digital Library*. 2016
- John Lee Clark. "Against Access" *McSweeney's Audio Issue 64*. 2021.

Week 11 (Nov 2) - Library Research Day

Research question & five sources due

Week 12 (Nov 9) - Writing Day II

Outline due

Mini-conferences with professor

Week 13 (Nov 16) - Review Paper Workshop I

First half of draft (at least 5 pages) due

Mini-conferences with professor, continued

Week 14 (Nov 23)- Fieldwork presentations

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CLASS IS ONLINE

All fieldwork write-ups due

How to write a reverse outline

Week 15 (Nov 30) - Writing Day II

How to write a hook

Week 16 (Dec 7) - Review Paper Workshop II

Full draft (at least 10 pages) due

Final papers due December 8th, 11:59pm

Policies

The following abbreviated set of policies is especially relevant to this class. Full details on policies and procedures can be found on the Pratt website or in the Office of the Vice President for Student Affairs, Main Building, Lower Level.

Community Standards

All Pratt students, faculty, and staff members are expected to value and uphold the community standards essential to the pursuit of academic excellence and social responsibility. These include expectations for social conduct, academic integrity, non-discrimination, and other policies described in the link above, and apply to all Pratt-sponsored activities, on or off campus.

Academic Integrity

Academic integrity at Pratt means using your own and original ideas in creating academic work. It also means that if you use the ideas or influence of others in your work, you must acknowledge them.

At Pratt,

- We do our own work,
- We are creative, and
- We give credit where it is due.

When students submit any work for academic credit, they make an implicit claim that the work is wholly their own, completed without the assistance of any unauthorized person. These works include, but are not limited to exams, quizzes, presentations, papers, projects, studio work, and other assignments and assessments. In addition, no student shall prevent another student from making their work. Students may study, collaborate, and work together on assignments at the discretion of the instructor.

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Examples of infractions include but are not limited to:

1. Plagiarism, defined as using the exact language or a close paraphrase of someone else's ideas without citation.
2. Violations of fair use, including the unauthorized and uncited use of another's artworks, images, designs, etc.
3. The supplying or receiving of completed work including papers, projects, outlines, artworks, designs, prototypes, models, or research for submission by any person other than the author.
4. The unauthorized submission of the same or essentially the same piece of work for credit in two different classes.
5. The use of generative artificial intelligence (AI) to produce or to improve work, whether visual or textual, except when called for by an assignment or instructor and acknowledged transparently as one tool among others in the creative process.

The Academic Integrity Standing Committee (AISC) is charged with educating faculty, staff, and students about academic integrity practices. Whenever possible, we strive to resolve alleged infractions at the most local level possible, such as between student and professor, or within a department or school. When necessary, members of this committee will form an Academic Integrity Hearing Board to hear cases regarding cheating, plagiarism, and other infractions described below; these infractions can be grounds for citation, sanction, or dismissal. Detailed procedures are explained in the full version of the Academic Integrity Policy.

Attendance Policy

Consistent attendance is essential for the completion of any course or program. Attending class does not earn students any specific portion of their grade, but is the pre-condition for passing the course, while missing class may seriously harm a student's grade. Pratt Institute respects students' requirements to observe days of cultural significance, including religious holy days, and recognizes that some students might need to miss class to do so. In this, or other similar, circumstance, students are responsible for consulting with faculty ahead of time about how and when they can make up work they will miss. Reasonable accommodations for students with documented disabilities will continue to be provided, as appropriate. For full details, see Pratt's Attendance Policy.

The expectations for this class are as follows:

In this course, attendance is very important, as each class session covers an entire week of instruction. Additionally, because much of class activity is spent in discussion, it is not possible to make up class work. More than two unexcused absences will begin to affect your grade negatively. Please reach out to me to communicate your specific circumstances. I will work with students who are proactive about their attendance to help them perform as best as possible in the course.

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Academic Support

Multiple academic support resources are available to students across campus:

- For assistance with time management and/or studio, subject, and software tutoring, contact the Student Success Center at success@pratt.edu.
- For assistance with writing assignments, contact the Writing and Tutorial Center at wtc@pratt.edu. The Pratt Libraries can also help with research and citations.
- Academic advisors are also a great resource; students can find their advisor's contact information or schedule an appointment through Starfish.

Accessibility

The Learning/Access Center (L/AC) coordinates access for students with disabilities. Students who identify as having any type of disability are entitled and encouraged to enroll with the L/AC in order to determine and implement reasonable accommodations. Contact the Learning/Access Center at lac@pratt.edu or 718.802.3123 for information or to schedule an appointment.

Title IX and Sexual Misconduct Policy

Pratt Institute is committed to fostering an environment that is safe, secure and free from sex discrimination and sexual harassment, sexual violence, dating and domestic violence, and stalking among all forms of sexual misconduct. The Institute takes prompt and appropriate action to address misconduct, end a hostile environment if one has been created, and prevent the recurrence of a hostile environment. To submit a concern, please use the Title IX and Sexual Misconduct Disclosure Form. For full details, see the Title IX and Sexual Misconduct Policy.

If you inform me of an issue of sex discrimination or sexual misconduct, I will keep the information as private as I can. However, as a faculty member, I am a mandatory reporter of sexual misconduct and required to bring it to the attention of the Institute's Title IX Coordinator, who can also be contacted at titleix@pratt.edu. You can also speak to someone confidentially by contacting our confidential resources in Health Services or the Counseling Center.

Nondiscrimination and Anti-Harassment Policy

Pratt is committed to fostering a welcoming, safe, non-discriminatory, and harassment-free educational, living, and working environment for its community. To submit a concern, please use the Discrimination and Harassment Disclosure Form, which also allows anonymous reports. For full details, see the Nondiscrimination and Anti-Harassment Policy.

Wellbeing

Pratt is dedicated to creating a culture where the entire community can flourish and thrive. Taking time to care for yourself and seeking appropriate support is important to achieving your academic and professional goals. Several resources are available through Starfish, including our Student Advocate and Care Coordinator, who can also be reached at 718.399.4546 or studentadvocate@pratt.edu. If you or anyone you know experiences overwhelming academic

stress, persistent difficult feelings, or challenging life events, the Counseling Center can be reached 24/7 by calling 718.687.5356. To schedule a consultation, please call or email therapy@pratt.edu

Starfish

Starfish provides students with contact information for advisors, instructors, department chairs, and support services across the campus. Faculty can also use Starfish to inform students of their progress in class and connect them with resources. Students are contacted by support offices whenever a flag is raised.

Public Safety & Emergency Contacts

The Department of Public Safety provides 24-hour-a-day protection to the campus, including an emergency response guide. Contact Public Safety at security@pratt.edu or 718.636.3540. The Pratt Emergency Alert System is used to send urgent messages to registered mobile devices and emails (faculty, staff, and students have the option to opt-out, which must be renewed each year). You can update your emergency contact information in the Safety section of OnePratt.